PIA3142 Global Social Movements — Week 5: Dynamics of Collective Mobilization

1. Where the Week Starts: Three Carried-Over Points (slide 2)

Keywords: own opportunities, event-driven, pressure on rivals, action/reaction cycles

- Effective movements **create their own opportunities** — they do not simply benefit from favourable circumstances.
- Protest is "event-driven": driven by choices, interactions, and chance, so the movement's trajectory and the outcome of its mobilization are not predictable at the outset.
- The movement must **keep pressure on rivals, push them into mistakes, and steer the action/reaction cycle** its way.

→ Can the course's "ingredients" be combined into one dynamic model?

2. The Dynamic Model: Question, Scope, Requirements (slides 2–4)

Keywords: dynamics, abstract situation, two requirements, overwhelming physical force

2.1 The Question — Modelling the "Dynamics" of Mobilization (slide 2)

Keywords: interactive and temporal, ingredients, collective action problem

- Can we model the "dynamics" of social movement mobilization: the interactive and temporal aspects of the process, built by combining the "ingredients" introduced when searching for a solution to the collective action problem (slide 2)?
- The task: combine opportunities, resources, framing, emotions, identities, and the Collective Action Problem into **one dynamic framework**.

2.2 Why Only an Abstract Model — and on What Assumption (slide 3)

Keywords: goals, contexts, opponents, freedom-and-equality movement, regime clinging to power

- Movements differ in **goals**, **contexts**, and **opponents**, so no single model fits all — model an **abstract situation** with implications for real cases.
- Assumption: a freedom-and-equality movement against a **regime intent on keeping power** — all claims are **conditional on this**.

2.3 The Two Requirements — Mobilise Numbers, Split the Regime (slide 4)

Keywords: mass mobilization, internal splits, unravelling from inside, Karklins & Petersen 1993

- The movement must (1) **mobilize as many people as possible** and (2) **create splits within the regime**, causing it to unravel.
- Modern states command **overwhelming physical force**, so regimes must lose their resolve and/or unravel from the inside — the movement must change the calculations of the officials who operate the state's coercive apparatus.
- Source: Rasma Karklins and Roger Petersen (1993), "The Decision Calculus of Protesters and Regimes: Eastern Europe, 1989," *Journal of Politics*.

3. The Empirical Case: Eastern Europe and the Collapse of Communism (slides 5–11)

Keywords: USSR, satellite regimes, unexpected collapse, weak civil society, revolutions of 1989, maps

3.1 Origins and the Unexpected Collapse — 1917 to Quasi-Totalitarianism (slides 5–7)

Keywords: revolution 1917, USSR 1922, WWII 1945, weak civil society, maps

- Regimes began with Russia's revolution (**1917**) and the USSR's birth (**1922**); after WWII (**1945**) most of Eastern Europe fell under repressive Soviet-style dictatorship.
- The late-1980s collapse was **quite unexpected**: the states seemed strong and capable of repression, yet the bloc's economics were failing and **civil society was extremely weak** (slide 5; maps, slides 6–7).

3.2 The Destabilising Sequence — Gorbachev to the Post-1989 Maps (slides 8–11)

Keywords: Hungary 1956, Czechoslovakia 1968, Gorbachev 1985, Poland 1988, 1989 revolutions, 15 successor states, Freedom House

- Earlier unrest was crushed **from outside** — Soviet intervention in **Hungary (1956)** and **Czechoslovakia (1968)**; later, Polish martial law and the **Solidarity** ban.
- **Gorbachev (1985)** abandoned Soviet intervention, and after **workers' strikes rocked Poland in 1988** the situation snowballed into the **1989 revolutions**: every bloc regime fell within months — by **negotiation** (Poland, Hungary, Bulgaria, Czechoslovakia) or **overthrow** (East Germany, Romania).
- Oppositions elsewhere were emboldened; by **1990** six republics declared independence, and after the failed **August 1991 coup** the USSR broke into **15 countries** (maps, slides 10–11; **Freedom House** — mostly **"NOT FREE"**).

4. Why Existing Theories Failed to Predict 1989 (slides 12–13)

Keywords: failed prediction, resource mobilization, rational choice, relative deprivation, political opportunity structure, Olson's question

Even the most engaged actors on both sides were unprepared (slide 12); four standard theories each miss the mechanism (slide 13).

4.1 What Surprised Everyone — Both Sides Unprepared (slide 12)

Keywords: East Germany, Czechoslovakia, October 1989, repressive powers still in place

- Karklins and Petersen (1993) open with the fall of 1989: the world was astounded by the protests toppling Eastern Europe's Communist regimes — yet **the most engaged actors on both sides were unprepared**.
- In **East Germany and Czechoslovakia (October 1989)** neither dissidents nor regimes expected collapse within weeks, though **both saw the repressive powers still in place** — *Example (the slide's own):* like the PRC, these governments could attack demonstrators and afterwards deny them jobs and promotions.

4.2 The Diagnosis — Four Theories, Four Failures (slide 13)

Keywords: no organizational preconditions, free-rider, timing, Tarrow, exogenous influences

- Resource Mobilization Theory — **no organizational preconditions** for effective protest.
- Rational Choice Theory — the **free-rider problem**.
- Relative Deprivation Theory — cannot explain **why protest began at that time** and grew day after day.
- Tarrow (1989, 1991)'s political opportunity structure — Gorbachev's reforms and Poland/Hungary events are real, but **exogenous influences alone cannot explain** the collective action that felled the bloc.
- Olson (1990, 16)'s frame: "How can autocratic regimes that appear to have such awesome power over their citizens collapse so quickly?"

→ None of the standard theories captures the process — a **dynamic model** is needed.

5. K&P's Answer: Event-Driven Conflict Dynamics (slides 14–15)

Keywords: action/reaction cycle, growing constituencies, regime cohesiveness, free riding, going first

5.1 The Two Simultaneous Effects — Wider Protest, Weaker Regime (slide 14)

Keywords: new constituencies, previously pro-regime groups, officials

- The answer: the **event-driven cycle of action and reaction** between regimes and oppositions.
- The cycle simultaneously **widened protest to new constituencies** (including previously pro-regime groups) and made regimes **lose the cohesiveness** to respond decisively — dictators are powerless without the officials who implement their dictates.

5.2 The Puzzle, Restated — Free Riding in a Dictatorship (slides 14–15)

Keywords: staying home, public good, violent repression, uncertainty, low confidence

- Even risk-free protest gives a self-interested individual an incentive to **stay home** and "free ride": let others bear the costs of producing the public good while enjoying its benefits.
- Dictatorships are worse: **institutionalized impunity** exposes protesters to **violent repression**; starting is hardest — (i) risk greatest when few protest, (ii) **great uncertainty** about the regime's response, (iii) **low confidence** in success (slide 15).
- Founding question: **how can a movement persuade someone to "go first"?**

6. The Individual Calculus: PROTECTION and PREDICTION (slide 16)

Keywords: two variables, physical repression, social sanction, regime collapse

Balance sheet (memorise) — K&P (1993) base the protester's calculus on **two considerations**:

6.1 The Two Variables — Protection from Sanctions, Prediction of Collapse (slide 16)

Keywords: physical repression, local environment, group size, observing the regime

- PROTECTION: protection from physical repression by the regime (protest size is key) and from social sanction in the "local environment" (shunning, dismissal, expulsion) — sanctions fall as more of one's social groups participate.
- PREDICTION: the chances the regime will collapse — judged by observing the behaviour of different social groups and of the regime itself.

7. The Tipping Point Model (slides 17–18)

Keywords: utility of demonstrating vs not, crossover point, nobody goes first

7.1 The Logic and the Figure — Utility Curves Crossing (slides 17–18)

Keywords: average person, regime change becomes likely, percentage protesting, rising vs falling curves

- For the "average person": with few protesters **not demonstrating is far better**; as numbers grow the gap shrinks until a **"tipping point"** where demonstrating beats staying home — so an "average person" alone would **never go first**.

- The tipping point is the level of participation at which the utility of demonstrating overtakes the utility of not demonstrating for a given individual or group.
- Slide 18 figure: **"Percentage Protesting"** (0–100%) against utility; demonstrating's utility (dashed, **rising**) crosses not-demonstrating's (solid, **falling**) near the mid-point.

8. Heterogeneity and the Four Groups (slides 19–22)

Keywords: diversity, different incentives, different risk tolerance, group-specific thresholds

8.1 The Average Person Doesn't Exist — Diversity of Thresholds (slide 19)

Keywords: personal attributes, social status and class, identity

- People differing in **attributes and dispositions**, **status and class**, and **identity** have **different incentives and risk tolerance** — hence **different tipping points**.
- Tipping points are group- and individual-specific thresholds: how much protest it takes to move a given kind of person depends on how much that kind of person has to lose.
- K&P (1993) focus on **four groups** especially important in Eastern Europe.

8.2 The Four Groups — Ascending Tipping Points (slide 20)

Keywords: dissidents, students, workers, party members/supporters — least to most to lose (memorise)

Memorise the order, lowest tipping point first:

- DISSIDENTS: known opponents already targeted for sanctions — least to lose, most willing to step out first.
- STUDENTS: careers at risk — a higher tipping point.
- WORKERS: could be fired — higher still.
- PARTY MEMBERS/SUPPORTERS: would act only if sure the regime would fall — the highest.
- *Example:* Charter 77; Prague students en masse, November 1989; Polish workers and Solidarity; Party supporters only once the fall was clear.

8.3 The Figure and "Courage Is Contagious" — Points A–D, Fairness and Shame (slides 21–22)

Keywords: hypothetical tipping points, sequence not simultaneity, fairness, respect, social integration

- Slide 22 figure: per group — **Party Supporter, Worker, Student, Dissident** — utility lines cross on the participation axis: **A (Dissident)** ~10%, **B (Student)** ~28%, **C (Worker)** ~48%, **D (Party Supporter)** ~72%.
- People's ideas of fairness and their desire for the respect of selves and others can make them want to join when others do, feel shame for doing nothing, or fear looking bad in others' eyes — participation is **not only instrumental calculation**, varying with **social integration and collective identity** (slide 21).

9. What Raises and Lowers Tipping Points (slide 23)

Keywords: perceived repression, predicted regime survival, social motivations, logistical costs

Tipping points are **not fixed**: they rise when repression looks likely and the regime looks likely to survive; they fall when repression looks unlikely and the regime might collapse; and they drop with stronger **"social motivations"** and resources that **cut logistical costs** — the course's "ingredients" **shift where the tipping points sit**.

10. The Early-Stage Strategy and the Contagion Mechanism (slide 24)

Keywords: prove the regime weak, chain reaction, snowball, each group as evidence for the next

- Early key move: **demonstrate to those staying home that the regime is weak**, not willing or able to repress effectively — **lowering each group's tipping point** and provoking a **chain reaction** in which protests **snowball**.
- The chain reaction ("contagion") effect: students join once the regime fails to stop dissidents; workers join once it fails to stop dissidents and students — each failure is evidence for the next group.
- But mobilization is not enough: the **regime must also unravel**.

11. The Other Half of the Model: How Regimes Unravel (slides 25–27)

Keywords: guards/officials/administrators, refusal to implement orders, parallel to protest dynamics, interlocking halves

11.1 The Parallel Logic — Officials as Tipping-Point Actors (slides 25–26)

Keywords: internal diversity, protection, regime survival, what other officials do

- Dictatorships are weak because the perceptions of "guards, officials, and administrators" can change, leading them to refuse to implement orders — triggered by the streets and running parallel to protest participation (slide 25).
- "Regimes" are **internally diverse** like the population: officials weigh their **"protection"** and their **expectation of regime survival**, and act on **what other officials do** (slide 26).

11.2 The Conclusion, Quoted in Full — Protest and Doubt Spread (slide 27)

Keywords: day-after-day demonstration, officials upgrade collapse probabilities, soldiers recalculate

- K&P (1993): "When the society as a whole has reached the tipping point and is demonstrating day after day without individual fear of physical sanctions, regime officials upgrade the probabilities of regime collapse. When the social groups that have joined the protest process include not only students but workers, soldiers will recalculate the chances of other soldiers firing upon the crowd. In turn, the regime elite will need to recalculate its ability to rely on the soldiers under these new conditions."
- → The **same tipping-point logic** that spreads protest through society spreads **doubt through the regime** — the two halves interlock.

12. The Two Puzzles K&P Concede (slide 28)

Keywords: who goes first, bandwagon effect, repression emboldens or scares, Week 7

- **Puzzle 1 — who goes first?** Dissidents tip lower as a group, but for the **first movers among them** protest is still **not instrumentally rational**.
- **Puzzle 2 — does repression backfire?** Regimes vary in using repression to prevent, stop, or reverse a "bandwagon effect" on protest: the self-reinforcing spread in which each new group that joins makes joining more attractive and safer for the next — sometimes repression **emboldens**, sometimes it **scares into submission**.
- → Puzzle 1 → the four factors (Section 13); Puzzle 2 → **Week 7**.

13. The Four Factors That Help Solve the Puzzles (slides 29–33)

Keywords: public goods motivations, informal assembling, demonstration effects, focal events — together they dramatically lower tipping points

13.1 The Four Factors — Definitions and Mapping (slides 29–33)

Keywords: discount private costs, first movers, informal ties, trust, belief updating, timing

- Public goods motivations: individuals driven by public concerns or emotion (discounting private costs), or who overestimate their contribution's impact — reduce others' perceived risks and increase social pressure to participate (slide 29).
- "Informal assembling processes": channels of information enabling coordination and common perceptions of events — informal social ties are key (trust, difficulty of detection) (slide 30).
- Demonstration effects: watching other communist countries and updating beliefs about repression and regime survival — lowering tipping points (slide 30).
- Focal events: repression can both escalate and de-escalate protest — which one depends on its timing and the information it sends (slide 33).
- Mapping: **1** answers "who goes first"; **2–3** spread coordination and belief-updating; **4** decides whether repression helps or backfires. Focal events come **formally only afterwards** — one argument, not two.

14. The Regime's Repressive Calculus and Why It Failed (slides 31–33)

Keywords: prophylactic vs open repression, "constant meaning", focal event, counterfactual

14.1 The Calculus, Quoted in Full — The Escalation Ladder (slide 31)

Keywords: decapitation, deterrent kept in reserve, escalation ladder, concessions

- K&P (1993) explain the regimes' "repressive calculus" — the failure to use the right kind of repression at the right time: "At very low levels of protest, use prophylactic repression (control dissident organisational capacities and isolate dissident leaders in order to decapitate potential protest movements); do not use open repression because its deterrent effect is much more powerful if kept in reserve, as the uncertainty concerning its use can be as powerful as its actual use. If prophylactic repression fails, use open but limited repression. If protest continues to grow, use open repression before things get out of hand. If demonstrations reach and maintain a level so large that open repression seems infeasible, initiate minor concessions. If protest is unaffected by minor concessions, grant major concessions."
- *Example:* martial law and the Solidarity ban in Poland (slide 8) — prophylactic repression: controlling capacity and isolating leaders.

14.2 Why It Failed and the Counterfactual — "No Constant Meaning" (slides 32–33)

Keywords: demonstration effects, public goods motivations, dissidents to students, too late

- The strategy was reasonable but assumed **"repression has a constant meaning"** — undermined by **demonstration effects** (prophylaxis had been overcome elsewhere), **informal assembling**, and **public goods motivations**, which spread protest **from dissidents to students**.
- More incisive repression created a "focal event" — a moment of repression that, by its timing and information, unites rather than divides protesters and signals weakness rather than strength — and **backfired**.
- K&P (1993)'s counterfactual: heavier repression from the start might have **saved the regimes — East Germany and Czechoslovakia** acted only when it was **too late**, read as **desperation**, not strength.

15. Repression: Escalate or De-escalate Protest? (slides 34–35)

Keywords: timing, information, unite vs divide, strength vs weakness, capitulation

One-liner: whether repression works depends on **when** it is used and **what it tells protesters**.

15.1 The Deciding Questions and the Outcome — Unite or Divide, Too Little, Too Late (slides 34–35)

Keywords: outrage and urge to strike back, sign of strength or weakness, overwhelming force, lost will

- Two questions decide the effect: does repression **unite or divide** protesters (uniting = shared outrage, an urge to strike back)? Does it read as **strength or weakness**?
- In Eastern Europe it came when **protest was already too widespread**, and the prescription was **overwhelming force** — but **indecision and apologies** signalled a regime that had **lost the will to fight**; protests grew, discipline broke down, and leaders could only **capitulate** — Section 11's unravelling, driven by the regime's **own mistakes**.

16. From Model to Framework: Seven Steps for Analysing Dynamics (slides 35–39)

Keywords: too abstract or too case-specific, one integrated framework, exam-friendly

The model is too abstract or too case-specific to apply everywhere (slide 35), but suggests a general approach — seven steps (exam-friendly):

16.1 The Seven Steps — A General Template (slides 36–39)

Keywords: bandwagon vs containment, gradual CAP resolution, contagion, tactics, mutual adaptation, timing

1. **Two-sided battle** (slide 36): movements seek a **bandwagon effect** and the **unravelling of the other side**; opponents contain mobilization and protect their own **cohesiveness and resolve**.
2. **Gradual resolution of the Collective Action Problem** (slides 36–37): identify key groups — interests, incentives, constraints, cohesion, integration, internal diversity — and their **tipping points**; assess structural factors (how society is organised, how context predisposes groups to act, how institutions set opportunities and challenges) plus movement resources, messaging, and activities that change perceptions, emotions, and identities.
3. **How protest spreads** (slide 37): contagion to and within constituencies — what makes it more or less likely.
4. **Movement tactics** (slide 38): raise perceived **safety** and **prospects of success**; expose the opponent's **weakness**; provoke **mistakes** that outrage supporters; foster **collective identity** and moral obligation; **undermine the opponent's resolve**.
5. **Opponent tactics** (slide 38): how governments, corporations, etc. neutralise movements and make them **unravel and collapse**.
6. **Mutual adaptation** (slide 39): both sides learn and change tactics to keep an edge.
7. **Timing and context** (slide 39): any move's effect **varies with when it is made** in the conflict.

17. Limits of the Model and the Overall Takeaway (slide 39)

Keywords: interpretation through the prism of experience, meaning in context, template not theory

17.1 Meaning Is Contextual — and the Twofold Takeaway

Keywords: same occurrence read differently, expectations about effects, time and place

- Opponents and supporters **interpret the same occurrence differently at different times** — through the **prism of experience**.
- For participants and observers alike, the meaning of words, actions, or events is only understandable in context; assessing a course of action requires expectations about its effects at the time and place it is taken.
- **Substantively:** mobilization is a **dynamic, event-driven contest** — a movement wins by lowering successive groups' tipping points until protest snowballs and officials stop implementing orders.
- **Methodologically:** the model is **not a general theory but a template** — it organises the course's ingredients around the **two-sided interaction** and the **timing** that gives each move meaning.

18. One-Page Revision Spine

Keywords: whole-lecture compression, slide map, exam checklist

8. **Start (slide 2):** opportunities are self-made; protest is event-driven; push rivals into mistakes.
9. **Scope (slides 2–4):** only an abstract model; freedom/equality movement vs power-holding regime; mobilize numbers **and** split the regime.
10. **Source:** Karklins & Petersen (1993), *Journal of Politics* — the 1989 protests.
11. **Case (slides 5–11):** USSR 1922 → bloc 1945 (weak civil society) → Gorbachev 1985 → Poland 1988 → 1989 revolutions → 1991 coup → 15 states, mostly "not free."
12. **Theory failures (slide 13):** RM (no preconditions), rational choice (free-rider), RD (timing), P.O.S. (exogenous); Olson's question.
13. **Variables (slide 16): PROTECTION** (repression + local sanctions, rising with participation) and **PREDICTION** (odds of collapse).
14. **Tipping point (slides 17–18):** demonstrating's utility crosses non-demonstrating's; an "average person" never goes first.
15. **Groups (slides 19–22):** thresholds group-specific; **Dissidents < Students < Workers < Party supporters** (A–D ≈ 10/28/48/72%); courage contagious via fairness, shame, respect.
16. **Thresholds move (slide 23):** repression likely + regime safe → higher; repression unlikely + regime wobbling + social motivations → lower.
17. **Contagion (slide 24):** prove the regime weak; dissidents → students → workers, each failure evidence for the next.

18. **Unravelling (slides 25–27):** officials weigh protection, regime survival, others' behaviour; doubt spreads until orders go unimplemented.
19. **Puzzles (slide 28):** who goes first; repression emboldens or scares (→ Week 7).
20. **Four factors (slides 29–33):** public goods motivations; informal assembling; demonstration effects; focal events.
21. **Calculus (slide 31):** prophylactic → limited open → open → minor → major concessions; failed assuming repression has constant meaning; incisive repression created a focal event and backfired.
22. **Escalate/de-escalate (slides 34–35):** timing + information (unite vs divide; strength vs weakness); indecision and apologies signalled lost will.
23. **Seven steps (slides 35–39):** two-sided battle → gradual CAP resolution → contagion → movement tactics → opponent tactics → mutual adaptation → timing.
24. **Takeaway (slide 39):** meaning is contextual; structure sets the stage, but interaction, interpretation, and timing decide outcomes.